



PHOTO BY **SANDESH RAVIKUMAR**

In the early days, none of us knew anything about e-commerce. We wanted to change the way India buys and sells. Now, we can say that what we have here is a model made in India, made for India, and made by India.



Obviously, we are speaking of a lot more that can be done...

Oh yes! Penetration levels are at 1% or a maximum of 2%. I was born in Jamshedpur much before digital was even spoken of. One often paid in advance to buy things.

Today, I see people there buying upholstery online from Skipper (a well-known furnishing store) in Kolkata. We are speaking of a very different scenario where books, upholstery, [and even] an 800-litre refrigerator can be purchased through e-commerce. Digitisation has equalised all of us and it is great to see an ecosystem with the idea at the core of everything.



How critical is the customer in all this?

To us, it is about the

experience. Take a look at this office in Bengaluru. It looks exactly like any of Amazon's offices globally. We differentiate ourselves on the basis of culture and leadership principles. The first year after I joined, Amit Agarwal (then Amazon India's boss) and I did not speak about numbers at all. It was only around customer rating and the delivery promise. It is critical for us to focus all our attention on this. We will never indulge in gimmicky stuff and compromise

on the customer-facing experience. These are easy things to speak of, but most companies don't do it since it adds to costs. Now, we have millions of customers on Amazon Prime and the brand is very strong. It is about having a sustainable experience. The word 'customer' has to come up all the time. If you succeed with that, the customer will come back to you.



Where will innovation figure in the midst of all this?

We have to just keep the innovation funnel going. If our vision is to change the way India buys and sells, it gets even more important as the next 100 million customers, or the next 10 million sellers, come aboard. One is speaking of a market with a huge population and businesses around that come with scale. Frankly, we have a long, long way to go. It is very easy to quote numbers on the potential and opportunities in India, but we must innovate to succeed. This is a very competitive market as all of us know. If a one-day delivery was a big thing earlier, it is now down to getting that done in minutes. **BT**

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